

Waiting for the culture-shock crash you keep hearing is coming

7 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

You moved somewhere new a few weeks ago and it's going better than expected. You're bracing for that to flip, because waiting for bad news feels safer than trusting the good news is real.

THE GOAL

You're treating your good start as a debt you'll have to repay with a hard stretch later. That schedule doesn't exist.

CHECKLIST

A day here goes wrong, or you feel unexpectedly tired, low, or irritable, and the first thought is "here it comes."

- ☐ Say "here it comes" out loud or in your head the moment it shows up, before acting on it.
- ☐ Say in one plain sentence what actually happened today (a mistake, a tired evening, an argument), not "the crash."
- ☐ If today traces to one clear thing, do the thing that fixes it now: send it, say it, close it.
- ☐ Write one line noting what happened and what you did about it, dated, somewhere you'll see it again.
- ☐ If nothing set it off, do one ordinary thing that usually helps, like a walk or food, before reading more into it.
- ☐ Jot down that today felt off too, wherever you're keeping track of these days, even with no clear reason.
- ☐ Name one thing from the last few good weeks that's still true today, like your routine or a person you've met.
- ☐ Message or see one person actually near you tonight. If you're tempted to call home instead, do the local one first.
- ☐ Answer the thought "here it comes" out loud or in writing: "this is a rough day, not evidence of anything."
- ☐ Pick one ordinary thing already on your plan for tomorrow that has nothing to do with today's dip.
- ☐ If this low feeling has followed you for several days running and the ordinary things haven't helped, tell one person today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Don't make people back home your main outlet on a hard day here.
- 2 If you're avoiding people here, read that as the cost of homesickness landing on local ties, not a verdict on your friendships back home.
- 3 Feeling a bit homesick tends to ease on its own as the weeks pass, though how much varies a lot person to person.

What actually shapes a hard stretch is who's around you

DO

Most of the people interviewed pointed to the **ties they built with people around them**, not people back home, as what actually helped.

Most interviewees named supportive ties with people around them, locals or fellow students, as what shaped their adjustment. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

Don't make people back home your main outlet on a hard day here.

People who leaned that way, or who coped by avoiding the problem or blaming themselves, paid a real cost in rockier stress patterns overall. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

If you're avoiding people here, read that as the cost of homesickness landing on local ties, not a verdict on your friendships back home.

Homesickness's damage landed specifically on relationships with people in the new place, not on relationships with people from home. [Source 4](#)

The schedule you're bracing for doesn't exist

KNOW

Your good weeks don't obligate you to a hard stretch later.

Tested across decades, that exact shape never once turned into a **timeline that fits anyone's real experience**. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

You don't need a downward turn before your adjustment counts as real.

For their overall adjustment specifically, nobody in the group picked the graph showing a decline, only flat or rising ones. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Arriving somewhere new rarely hits like a shock or a high, and for most people it barely registers.

In a study of exchange students across many countries, most people's stress barely shifted on arrival, in either direction. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Feeling a bit homesick tends to ease on its own as the weeks pass, though how much varies a lot person to person.

On average, homesickness faded only a little across a full term, and how much it faded varied a lot by student. [Source 4](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

There's a rough timeline for this, like everyone hits a hard patch around the same point, roughly three months in.

ACTUALLY

How much this varies between people is exactly why no single point in time can predict your case. A pattern that fits one person can say **nothing about the next**. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. https://www.nafsa.org/sites/default/files/ektron/files/underscore/theory_connections_adjustment.pdf
2. https://eprints.ncl.ac.uk/file_store/production/290946/8BFB8790-D5EF-492F-B5EC-52292501D23F.pdf
3. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4507515/>
4. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC5280212/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Moving somewhere new at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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